

The Social Science Disciplines

The social sciences are not a single, monolithic field of study. They comprise multiple distinct disciplines, each with its own focus, methods, theories, and professional pathways. Anthropology asks what it means to be human across time and space. Economics examines how scarce resources are produced, distributed, and consumed. Geography studies the relationship between people and place. Political Science analyzes power, governance, and political behavior. Psychology investigates the mind and behavior of individuals. Sociology and Demography explore social structures, groups, and population dynamics. History reconstructs and interprets the past. Linguistics examines language as a human and social phenomenon. Each discipline offers unique tools for understanding society, and each opens distinct career opportunities.

This reading material examines various social science disciplines in terms of their fields, main areas of inquiry, methods, theories, and approaches. It analyzes Political Science in understanding power, governance, political behavior, major political theories, and key methods of political inquiry. It explains diverse career opportunities in government, law, international relations, research, media, advocacy, and security. It evaluates economics as a social science, including its theories, methods, career opportunities, and the influence of globalization. It analyzes key theories, methods, and careers in sociology and anthropology, and compares these two disciplines in terms of how they understand societies and culture. It also analyzes key theories, methods, and careers in Geography, History, and Linguistics. Finally, it covers Psychology and Sociology with Demography as distinct disciplines within the social sciences.

Part 1: Anthropology – The Study of Humanity

Anthropology is the holistic study of human beings across time and space. Unlike other disciplines that focus on a single aspect of humanity, anthropology seeks to understand the full scope of human experience – biological, cultural, linguistic, and archaeological. Anthropologists ask fundamental questions: Where did humans come from? Why do cultures differ? What do all humans share? How have societies changed over thousands

of years? To answer these questions, anthropologists immerse themselves in other ways of life, often living for extended periods within the communities they study. This immersive approach, called ethnography, distinguishes anthropology from other social sciences.

Fields of Anthropology

Field	Focus
Cultural Anthropology	The study of contemporary cultures, customs, beliefs, and social practices
Physical (Biological) Anthropology	Human evolution, genetics, primatology, and biological variation
Linguistic Anthropology	Language as a cultural and social phenomenon; how language shapes thought and identity
Archaeology	The study of past societies through material remains (artifacts, structures, landscapes)

Main Areas of Inquiry

Area	Questions Asked
Kinship and social organization	How do societies organize family and descent? What are the rules of marriage?
Ritual and religion	What do people believe about the supernatural? How do rituals create community?
Economic anthropology	How do non-Western societies produce, exchange, and consume goods?

Area	Questions Asked
Political anthropology	How do societies maintain order without formal governments?
Medical anthropology	How do culture and belief shape health, illness, and healing practices?

Key Theories in Anthropology

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Cultural Evolutionism	Edward Tylor, Lewis Henry Morgan	Societies evolve from simple to complex (savagery → barbarism → civilization)
Historical Particularism	Franz Boas	Each culture has its own unique history; no universal stages of evolution
Structuralism	Claude Lévi-Strauss	Human minds organize experience through binary oppositions (raw/cooked, nature/culture)
Symbolic Anthropology	Clifford Geertz	Culture is a system of meanings expressed through symbols; aim is thick description
Feminist Anthropology	Margaret Mead, various	Critiques male bias in anthropological research; focuses on gender as a social construct
Postcolonial Anthropology	Various	Examines how colonialism shaped anthropological knowledge; advocates for decolonizing the discipline

Key Methods in Anthropology

Method	Description
Ethnography (Participant Observation)	Living within a community for extended periods, participating in daily life while observing and taking notes
Ethnology	Cross-cultural comparison to identify patterns and differences across societies
Genealogical Method	Tracing kinship relations to understand family structure and descent
Archaeological Excavation	Systematic digging to uncover artifacts, features, and ecofacts from past societies
Linguistic Analysis	Recording, transcribing, and analyzing languages, including endangered languages

Career Opportunities in Anthropology

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Cultural Resource Management	Environmental firms, government agencies	Identifying and preserving archaeological sites before construction projects
Museum Curator	Museums, cultural centers	Managing collections, designing exhibits, conducting research
Forensic Anthropologist	Law enforcement, medical examiner offices	Identifying human remains, assisting in criminal investigations

Development Anthropologist	NGOs, international development agencies	Ensuring development projects are culturally appropriate
Academic Researcher	Universities, research institutes	Conducting research, publishing findings, teaching students
Corporate Anthropologist	Tech companies, marketing firms	Studying user behavior, improving product design (user experience research)

Part 2: Economics – The Study of Scarcity and Choice

Economics is the social science that studies how individuals, firms, governments, and societies make choices under conditions of scarcity. Because resources are limited – time, money, labor, raw materials – people cannot have everything they want. Economics examines how these choices are made, how markets coordinate individual decisions, and how policies can improve or worsen economic outcomes. Unlike the popular perception that economics is only about money, economists study a wide range of human behavior, from consumer choice to crime rates, from marriage decisions to environmental protection. Globalization has profoundly transformed economics, creating integrated global markets, multinational corporations, and complex supply chains that connect producers and consumers across continents.

Fields of Economics

Field	Focus
Microeconomics	Individual decision-making by households and firms; supply and demand; market structures
Macroeconomics	Economy-wide phenomena: inflation, unemployment, economic growth, international trade

Field	Focus
Development Economics	Economic growth and poverty reduction in low-income countries
Behavioral Economics	How psychological factors (biases, heuristics, emotions) affect economic decisions
Environmental Economics	Economic impact of environmental policies; valuation of natural resources
Labor Economics	Wages, employment, discrimination, human capital, migration
International Economics	Trade, exchange rates, global capital flows, effects of globalization

Main Areas of Inquiry

Area	Questions Asked
Scarcity and choice	How do individuals and societies decide what to produce, how to produce, and for whom?
Supply and demand	How do prices coordinate the actions of buyers and sellers?
Market structures	How do monopolies, oligopolies, and perfect competition affect prices and output?
Economic growth	What causes some economies to grow faster than others?
Inequality	Why do some people earn more than others? How does globalization affect income distribution?

Market failures	When do markets produce inefficient outcomes (pollution, monopoly, information asymmetry)?
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Key Theories in Economics

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Classical Economics	Adam Smith, David Ricardo	Free markets, guided by the invisible hand, produce prosperity; comparative advantage explains trade
Marxian Economics	Karl Marx	Capitalism contains internal contradictions; exploitation of labor leads to crisis and eventual revolution
Neoclassical Economics	Alfred Marshall, Léon Walras	Value determined by utility (consumers) and marginal productivity (producers); mathematical models of equilibrium
Keynesian Economics	John Maynard Keynes	In recessions, markets may not clear; government spending can restore full employment
Monetarism	Milton Friedman	Inflation is always and everywhere a monetary phenomenon; central banks should target money supply
Behavioral Economics	Daniel Kahneman, Richard Thaler	Humans are not perfectly rational; cognitive biases systematically affect economic decisions

Key Methods in Economics

Method	Description
Mathematical Modeling	Using equations to represent economic relationships (supply, demand, production functions)
Statistical Analysis (Econometrics)	Using data to test economic theories and estimate causal effects
Controlled Experiments	Laboratory or field experiments to study economic behavior (e.g., game theory experiments)
Natural Experiments	Observing real-world events that approximate random assignment (e.g., policy changes)
Cost-Benefit Analysis	Comparing total costs and total benefits of a policy or project

Career Opportunities in Economics

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Economic Analyst	Banks, investment firms, corporations	Forecasting market trends, analyzing financial data, assessing risk
Policy Analyst	Government agencies (Treasury, Labor), think tanks	Evaluating economic policies, writing reports, advising policymakers
Development Economist	World Bank, IMF, UN, NGOs	Designing poverty reduction programs, evaluating aid effectiveness
Data Scientist	Tech companies, consulting firms	Analyzing large datasets, building predictive models

Academic Economist	Universities, research institutes	Teaching, conducting research, publishing in journals
Regulatory Economist	Government regulatory agencies	Analyzing costs and benefits of regulations (environmental, consumer protection)

Globalization and Economics

Globalization has fundamentally reshaped economics as a discipline and as a lived reality. Economists now study global supply chains, international capital flows, multinational corporations, outsourcing, and the economic effects of migration. Globalization has created unprecedented prosperity in many countries (e.g., China, India) but has also contributed to job displacement and wage stagnation in some high-income countries. Economists debate the net effects of globalization and the appropriate policy responses, including trade agreements, tariffs, labor standards, and social safety nets.

Part 3: Geography – The Study of Space, Place, and Environment

Geography is the social science that studies the relationship between human societies and the physical environment, with a focus on spatial patterns and processes. Geographers ask where things are located, why they are there, and how they interact across space. Unlike other social sciences that often treat space as a neutral backdrop, geography insists that space matters – that location, distance, and spatial relationships shape economic outcomes, cultural patterns, political behavior, and environmental conditions. Geography is divided into physical geography (landforms, climate, vegetation) and human geography (the social, cultural, economic, and political dimensions of space). Both branches are essential for understanding contemporary issues such as urbanization, climate change, resource management, and globalization.

Fields of Geography

Field	Focus
Human Geography	Spatial organization of human activities: cities, regions, migration, culture, economy, politics
Physical Geography	Natural features of Earth's surface: landforms, climate, soils, vegetation, hydrology
Geographic Information Science (GIScience)	Development and application of GIS, remote sensing, and spatial analysis tools
Environmental Geography	Human-environment interaction: resource use, pollution, conservation, environmental justice
Urban Geography	Cities, urbanization, suburbanization, urban planning, inequality within cities
Political Geography	Boundaries, borders, geopolitics, territoriality, electoral geography
Economic Geography	Spatial distribution of economic activity: industry location, global supply chains, regional development

Main Areas of Inquiry

Area	Questions Asked
Spatial distribution	Where are things located? Why are they there?
Human-environment interaction	How do humans modify the environment? How does the environment constrain or enable human activity?

Region and place	What makes one place different from another? How do places develop unique identities?
Movement and diffusion	How do people, goods, ideas, and diseases spread across space?
Scale	How do processes at local, regional, national, and global scales interact?
Mapping and representation	How do maps reflect and shape our understanding of the world?

Key Theories in Geography

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Environmental Determinism	Friedrich Ratzel, Ellsworth Huntington	Human societies are largely determined by physical environment (largely rejected)
Possibilism	Paul Vidal de la Blache	Environment sets constraints, but humans have multiple possible responses
Spatial Science	Walter Christaller, August Lösch	Geography as a science of spatial patterns and processes; laws of spatial organization
Behavioral Geography	Various	How individuals perceive, make decisions about, and navigate space
Critical Geography	David Harvey, Doreen Massey	Space is socially produced; geography is shaped by capitalism, class, and power
Feminist Geography	Gillian Rose, Doreen Massey	How gender shapes and is shaped by spatial relations; critique of male bias in geography

Key Methods in Geography

Method	Description
Geographic Information Systems (GIS)	Computer-based mapping and spatial analysis of multiple data layers
Remote Sensing	Analyzing satellite or aerial imagery to study land use, vegetation, urban growth
Fieldwork	Direct observation, mapping, and data collection in specific locations
Spatial Statistics	Statistical methods that account for spatial autocorrelation and distance effects
Qualitative Methods	Interviews, ethnography, discourse analysis to understand place meaning
Cartography	The art and science of mapmaking; design and communication of spatial information

Career Opportunities in Geography

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
GIS Specialist	Government, utilities, environmental consulting	Creating maps, analyzing spatial data, managing geographic databases
Urban and Regional Planner	Municipal government, planning firms	Designing land use plans, zoning regulations, transportation networks
Environmental Consultant	Environmental firms, government agencies	Assessing environmental impact of development projects, remediation planning

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Climatologist	Weather services, research institutes	Studying climate patterns, modeling climate change impacts
Transportation Planner	Government transit agencies, consulting	Analyzing traffic patterns, planning public transit routes
Location Analyst	Retail corporations, real estate firms	Determining optimal locations for stores or facilities using GIS
Remote Sensing Analyst	Government (NASA, military), agricultural firms	Interpreting satellite imagery for land use, crop monitoring, disaster response

Part 4: History – The Study of the Past

History is the social science that studies past events, their causes, and their consequences. Historians do not simply memorize dates and names. They interpret evidence, construct narratives, and debate competing explanations of why things happened the way they did. History is sometimes classified as a humanities discipline (because of its emphasis on narrative and interpretation), but it is also a social science because of its systematic methods, its attention to causation and social structures, and its use of evidence to test claims. In the Philippine context, the term *Kasaysayan* carries deeper meaning than the English word "history." It derives from the root word *saysay*, which means meaning, sense, or significance. Thus, *Kasaysayan* is not merely the recording of past events but the recovery of meaning and relevance for the present and future.

Fields of History

Field	Focus
Political History	Study of governance, leaders, elections, wars, diplomacy

Field	Focus
Social History	Study of ordinary people, social structures, family, class, labor, everyday life
Economic History	Study of past economies, trade, industry, agriculture, technological change
Cultural History	Study of ideas, beliefs, arts, popular culture, intellectual movements
Intellectual History	Study of thinkers, philosophies, and the development of ideas over time
Diplomatic History	Study of relations between states, treaties, international organizations
Local and Regional History	Study of specific places, communities, or regions (e.g., Philippine local history)
Oral History	Collection and analysis of personal memories and eyewitness accounts

Main Areas of Inquiry

Area	Questions Asked
Causation	Why did this event happen? What combination of factors (economic, political, social, cultural) produced it?
Change over time	How have societies, institutions, or ideas transformed across different periods?
Continuity	What structures or practices have persisted despite change? Why?

Area	Questions Asked
Contingency	Could history have unfolded differently? Which events turned on chance decisions or small causes?
Agency	Which individuals or groups shaped historical outcomes? How?
Representation	How have historians constructed narratives of the past? Whose voices have been included or excluded?

Key Theories and Approaches in History

Theory/Approach	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Historicism	Leopold von Ranke	History should be written "as it actually happened" using primary sources; avoid present-day judgments
Marxist History	Karl Marx, E.P. Thompson	Class struggle is the engine of history; economic base determines political and ideological superstructure
Annales School	Marc Bloch, Fernand Braudel	Long-term social and economic structures (longue durée) matter more than events and individuals
Postcolonial History	Edward Said, Dipesh Chakrabarty	Examines how colonialism shaped historical knowledge; recovers subaltern (marginalized) voices

Feminist History	Joan Scott, Gerda Lerner	Recovers women's history; analyzes gender as a category of historical analysis
Microhistory	Carlo Ginzburg	Intensive study of a small event or person to reveal larger historical forces

Key Methods in History

Method	Description
Primary Source Analysis	Examining original documents, letters, diaries, government records, photographs, artifacts
Secondary Source Analysis	Reading and synthesizing other historians' interpretations
Archival Research	Working in archives to discover unpublished or unexamined documents
Oral History	Conducting and analyzing interviews with witnesses or participants of past events
Historiography	Studying how historical interpretations have changed over time
Comparative History	Comparing events or processes across different societies or time periods

Career Opportunities in History

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Archivist	Libraries, government archives, universities	Preserving, cataloging, and providing access to historical documents

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Museum Curator	Museums, historical societies	Managing collections, designing exhibits, conducting research
History Teacher	Secondary schools, colleges, universities	Teaching history courses at various levels
Historical Consultant	Film, television, legal firms	Providing historical expertise for documentaries, legal cases, or media productions
Preservationist	Historic preservation agencies, non-profits	Identifying and protecting historic buildings and sites
Researcher	Government, think tanks, corporations	Conducting historical research to inform policy or business decisions
Genealogist	Private practice, libraries	Tracing family histories using historical records

Part 5: Linguistics – The Study of Language

Linguistics is the social science that studies language – its structure, its variation, its change over time, and its role in social life. Language is so fundamental to human experience that it is often invisible, like the air one breathes. Linguists make language visible by analyzing its patterns: how sounds combine into words, how words combine into sentences, how meaning is created, and how language varies across social groups, regions, and historical periods. Language is not merely a tool for communication; it shapes thought, marks identity, and carries power. Understanding linguistics means understanding what it means to be human, because no human society exists without language.

Fields of Linguistics

Field	Focus
Phonetics	The physical production and perception of speech sounds
Phonology	The systematic organization of sounds in particular languages
Morphology	The structure of words and how they are formed from smaller units (morphemes)
Syntax	The rules for combining words into grammatical sentences
Semantics	The study of meaning in language
Pragmatics	How context affects the interpretation of meaning (e.g., irony, politeness, implication)
Sociolinguistics	The relationship between language and society: dialect, class, gender, ethnicity, identity
Historical Linguistics	Language change over time: how languages evolve, split, and sometimes die
Psycholinguistics	The cognitive processes underlying language production and comprehension
Anthropological Linguistics	Language as a cultural resource; the relationship between language and worldview

Main Areas of Inquiry

Area	Questions Asked
Language structure	What are the universal properties of human language? How do languages differ systematically?
Language variation	How does language vary across region (dialect), social class (sociolect), and situation (register)?
Language change	Why do languages change over time? How are new words created?
Language and identity	How does language signal belonging to a social group? How do people use language to perform identity?
Language and power	How is language used to dominate, exclude, or resist? What is linguisticism (discrimination based on language)?
Language acquisition	How do children learn their first language? How do adults learn second languages?

Key Theories in Linguistics

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Structuralism	Ferdinand de Saussure	Language is a system of differences; meaning comes from relationships (syntagmatic and paradigmatic)
Generative Grammar	Noam Chomsky	Humans have an innate Universal Grammar; surface structures derived from deep structures via transformations

Functionalism	Michael Halliday	Language is shaped by its communicative functions; form follows function
Sociolinguistic Variation	William Labov	Language varies systematically with social factors (class, age, gender); variation is structured, not random
Critical Discourse Analysis	Norman Fairclough	Language reproduces social power and ideology; analyzing discourse reveals hidden assumptions
Linguistic Relativity (Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis)	Edward Sapir, Benjamin Whorf	Language shapes thought; different languages lead to different worldviews (strong vs. weak versions)

Key Methods in Linguistics

Method	Description
Elicitation	Asking native speakers to provide grammatical judgments or translations
Corpus Analysis	Analyzing large, computer-searchable collections of natural language (text or speech)
Fieldwork	Working directly with speakers of under-documented languages, often in remote communities
Experimental Phonetics	Using instruments (spectrographs, ultrasound) to measure speech production
Discourse Analysis	Analyzing extended stretches of conversation or text for patterns and strategies

Method	Description
Sociolinguistic Interview	Collecting natural speech from diverse speakers to study language variation

Career Opportunities in Linguistics

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Speech-Language Pathologist	Hospitals, schools, clinics	Diagnosing and treating speech and language disorders
Computational Linguist (NLP)	Tech companies (Google, Amazon, Apple)	Developing language technologies: speech recognition, machine translation, chatbots
Translator or Interpreter	Government, international organizations, private sector	Translating written text or interpreting spoken language between languages
Forensic Linguist	Law enforcement, legal firms	Analyzing language evidence in criminal cases (threats, authorship attribution, voice identification)
Language Teacher	Schools, universities, language institutes	Teaching English as a second language or foreign languages
Lexicographer	Dictionary publishers	Researching word meanings and usage; writing dictionary entries
Language Documentarian	Academic institutions, endangered language projects	Recording and preserving endangered languages before they disappear

Part 6: Political Science – The Study of Power and Governance

Political Science is the social science that studies power, governance, and political behavior. It asks fundamental questions: Who governs? How is power acquired, exercised, and justified? Why do some governments collapse while others endure? How do citizens participate in political life? Political scientists examine everything from voting behavior in local elections to international diplomacy between superpowers. Unlike casual commentary on politics, political science uses systematic methods, comparative analysis, and theoretical frameworks to understand political phenomena. It is not about partisan advocacy (supporting one party over another) but about analyzing how political systems work. The discipline prepares students for careers in government, law, international relations, research, media, advocacy, and security.

Main Areas of Inquiry in Political Science

Area	Questions Asked
Power	Who has power? How is power exercised and resisted? What is the difference between authority, coercion, and influence?
Governance	How are societies organized and ruled? What makes institutions effective or ineffective?
Political Behavior	Why do people vote the way they do? How do social movements form? What shapes public opinion?
Political Systems	How do democracies differ from authoritarian regimes? What explains democratization?
Public Policy	How are policies made? Why do some policies succeed and others fail?
International Relations	Why do states go to war? How do international institutions (UN, WTO) shape global politics?

Key Methods of Political Inquiry

Method	Description
Comparative Politics	Comparing political systems across countries to identify patterns and causal explanations
Case Study	In-depth analysis of a single country, election, or policy to understand mechanisms
Statistical Analysis	Using quantitative data (elections, surveys, economic indicators) to test hypotheses
Surveys and Public Opinion Research	Measuring citizen attitudes, beliefs, and preferences
Institutional Analysis	Examining formal rules (constitutions, laws) and informal norms that shape political behavior
Historical Analysis	Tracing political developments over time to understand causation and contingency
Game Theory	Modeling strategic interactions among political actors (voters, legislators, states)

Major Political Theories

Theory	Core Idea	Key Thinkers
Liberalism	Individual rights, limited government, consent of the governed, free markets	John Locke, John Stuart Mill

Realism	International politics is a struggle for power among self-interested states; morality is secondary	Thucydides, Hans Morgenthau
Marxism	Politics is shaped by class struggle; the state serves the interests of the ruling class	Karl Marx, Vladimir Lenin
Conservatism	Tradition, order, stability; skepticism of rapid change; hierarchy is natural	Edmund Burke
Feminism	Political theory has been male-dominated; gender shapes power relations	Carole Pateman, Iris Marion Young
Postcolonialism	Colonialism continues to shape global power relations; examines perspectives of formerly colonized peoples	Edward Said, Frantz Fanon

Career Opportunities in Political Science

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Government Official	Executive branch (local, national), legislature, civil service	Policy development, program administration, legislative research
Lawyer	Private practice, government, non-profits	Legal research, advocacy, litigation, constitutional interpretation
Diplomat / Foreign Service Officer	Department of Foreign Affairs, embassies abroad	Representing national interests abroad, negotiating treaties, assisting citizens overseas
Policy Analyst	Think tanks (e.g., CSIS, FES), research institutes	Researching policy issues, writing reports, advising policymakers

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Political Consultant	Campaigns, political parties	Advising candidates on strategy, messaging, voter targeting
Legislative Aide	Congress, Senate, local legislatures	Researching legislation, drafting bills, constituent services
Journalist / Political Correspondent	News organizations (print, broadcast, digital)	Covering politics, analyzing elections, interviewing officials
Advocate / Lobbyist	Non-profits, advocacy groups, corporations	Influencing policy, mobilizing public opinion, meeting with legislators
Intelligence Analyst	Security agencies (military, police, national security)	Analyzing political and security threats, preparing briefings

Part 7: Psychology – The Study of Mind and Behavior

Psychology is the social science that studies the human mind, behavior, and mental processes. Psychologists investigate how individuals perceive, think, feel, and act. Unlike sociology, which focuses on groups and structures, psychology focuses on the individual level of analysis. Yet psychology is deeply connected to the social sciences because human behavior is always shaped by social context. Psychologists ask questions such as: How do people learn? What causes mental illness? How do memories form and fade? Why do people conform to group pressure? How do early childhood experiences shape adult personality? Psychology uses rigorous scientific methods, including experiments, surveys, and neuroimaging, to answer these questions.

Fields of Psychology

Field	Focus
Clinical Psychology	Diagnosis and treatment of mental disorders (depression, anxiety, schizophrenia)
Cognitive Psychology	Mental processes: memory, attention, problem-solving, decision-making, language
Developmental Psychology	Changes across the lifespan: childhood, adolescence, adulthood, aging
Social Psychology	How thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are influenced by other people (conformity, persuasion, prejudice)
Industrial-Organizational Psychology	Workplace behavior: motivation, leadership, job satisfaction, personnel selection
Educational Psychology	Learning processes, teaching methods, classroom dynamics
Biological (Physiological) Psychology	Brain mechanisms, hormones, genetics underlying behavior
Forensic Psychology	Psychology applied to legal contexts: criminal behavior, eyewitness testimony, jury decision-making

Key Theories in Psychology

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Psychoanalysis	Sigmund Freud	Unconscious drives, childhood experiences, and defense mechanisms shape personality and behavior

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Behaviorism	John Watson, B.F. Skinner	Psychology should study observable behavior only; behavior is shaped by reinforcement and punishment
Humanistic Psychology	Carl Rogers, Abraham Maslow	Emphasizes free will, self-actualization, and the inherent goodness of human nature
Cognitive Psychology	Jean Piaget, Ulric Neisser	Mental processes (memory, thinking, problem-solving) can be studied scientifically
Social Learning Theory	Albert Bandura	Learning occurs through observation and imitation of others (Bobo doll experiment)
Evolutionary Psychology	Various	Psychological mechanisms evolved to solve adaptive problems faced by ancestors

Key Methods in Psychology

Method	Description
Controlled Experiment	Manipulating an independent variable to measure its effect on a dependent variable; gold standard for causal inference
Correlational Study	Measuring the relationship between two variables without manipulation (cannot prove causation)
Survey / Questionnaire	Collecting self-reported data from large samples about attitudes, beliefs, behaviors
Case Study	In-depth study of a single individual or small group (often used in clinical psychology)

Method	Description
Naturalistic Observation	Observing behavior in natural settings without interference
Neuroimaging (fMRI, EEG)	Measuring brain activity while participants perform tasks
Longitudinal Study	Following the same participants over months, years, or decades to study change

Career Opportunities in Psychology

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Clinical Psychologist	Private practice, hospitals, mental health clinics	Diagnosing and treating mental disorders; providing therapy
Counseling Psychologist	Schools, universities, community centers	Providing guidance for life challenges (relationship, career, academic)
School Psychologist	Schools, school districts	Assessing students for learning disabilities; supporting emotional well-being
Industrial-Organizational Psychologist	Corporations, consulting firms	Improving employee selection, training, motivation, and workplace culture
Forensic Psychologist	Courts, prisons, law enforcement	Evaluating competency, assessing risk, providing expert testimony
Human Resources Specialist	Corporations, government agencies	Recruiting, training, employee relations, performance evaluation

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Market Researcher	Marketing firms, corporations	Studying consumer behavior using psychological principles
Academic Psychologist	Universities, research institutes	Teaching, conducting research, publishing findings

Part 8: Sociology and Demography – The Study of Society and Population

Sociology is the social science that studies human society, social structures, groups, institutions, and social relationships. Sociologists ask how societies are organized, how they change, and how individuals are shaped by the social contexts in which they live. While psychology focuses on the individual, sociology focuses on the group, the institution, and the society. Demography is a subfield of sociology (though sometimes considered a separate discipline) that studies human populations – their size, composition, distribution, and changes over time due to births, deaths, and migration.

Comparison of Sociology and Anthropology

Sociology and anthropology share many interests, including culture, social structure, kinship, and ritual. However, they have historically differed in focus and method.

Dimension	Sociology	Anthropology
Historical Focus	Modern, industrial societies (Europe, North America)	Small-scale, non-Western, indigenous societies
Typical Method	Surveys, statistical analysis, interviews	Ethnography, participant observation, long-term fieldwork
Scale of	Large-scale social structures (class,	Small-scale communities, face-to-face

Dimension	Sociology	Anthropology
Analysis	inequality, institutions)	interactions
Stance	Often reformist (using research to address social problems)	Often relativist (understanding cultures on their own terms)
Key Concept	Social structure, institution, inequality	Culture, kinship, ritual, worldview

Note: These differences have blurred considerably. Contemporary sociologists use ethnography; contemporary anthropologists study modern urban societies. The two disciplines increasingly collaborate and share methods.

Fields of Sociology

Field	Focus
Social Stratification	Class, inequality, poverty, social mobility
Sociology of the Family	Marriage, divorce, parenting, family structures across cultures
Sociology of Education	Schools as social systems; inequality in educational outcomes
Urban Sociology	City life, neighborhoods, gentrification, suburbanization
Political Sociology	Relationship between society and politics; social movements; voting behavior
Economic Sociology	Social foundations of economic activity (networks, trust, institutions)
Sociology of Religion	Religious beliefs, practices, organizations, and secularization

Field	Focus
Criminology	Crime, deviance, punishment, prisons, juvenile delinquency
Medical Sociology	Health, illness, healthcare systems, doctor-patient relationships

Demography – The Study of Population

Focus	Questions Asked
Fertility	How many children do women have? What affects birth rates?
Mortality	What is the average lifespan? What causes death at different ages?
Migration	Why do people move? What are patterns of immigration and emigration?
Population Composition	What are the age, sex, race, and education distributions of a population?
Population Projection	How will populations change in the future? What are the implications for policy?

Key Theories in Sociology

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Functionalism	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons	Society is a system of interdependent parts; each institution serves a function to maintain stability
Conflict Theory	Karl Marx, C. Wright Mills	Society is characterized by conflict over scarce resources; the powerful dominate the weak

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Symbolic Interactionism	George Herbert Mead, Herbert Blumer	Society is built through everyday interactions and shared meanings; focus on micro-level
Feminist Theory	Dorothy Smith, Patricia Hill Collins	Sociology has been male-dominated; gender inequality permeates social structures
Rational Choice Theory	James Coleman	Individuals make decisions by weighing costs and benefits; aggregate choices produce social outcomes
Postmodernism	Michel Foucault, Jean Baudrillard	Rejects grand narratives; reality is socially constructed through discourse and power

Key Methods in Sociology

Method	Description
Social Survey	Collecting standardized data from large samples using questionnaires
In-depth Interview	Semi-structured or unstructured conversation to explore lived experience
Ethnography / Participant Observation	Extended immersion in a community to understand it from within
Statistical Analysis (Demography)	Analyzing census data, vital statistics, and survey data to identify population trends
Comparative Historical Sociology	Comparing societies or time periods to identify causal patterns

Method	Description
Network Analysis	Mapping social relationships (friendship, collaboration, influence) using graph theory

Career Opportunities in Sociology and Demography

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Social Worker	Government agencies, non-profits	Supporting vulnerable populations (children, elderly, homeless)
Policy Researcher	Think tanks, government, advocacy groups	Conducting research on social policies (poverty, housing, health)
Demographer	Census bureaus, planning departments, private firms	Analyzing population trends; projecting future population needs
Market Research Analyst	Corporations, marketing firms	Studying consumer demographics and preferences
Program Evaluator	Government, non-profits, foundations	Assessing whether social programs achieve their intended outcomes
Urban Planner	Municipal government, consulting	Designing communities; planning housing, transportation, parks
Survey Researcher	Research firms, universities	Designing and conducting surveys; analyzing survey data
Academic Sociologist	Universities, research institutes	Teaching, conducting research, publishing in journals

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Anthropology	The holistic study of human beings across time and space, including culture, biology, language, and material remains
Economics	The study of how individuals and societies make choices under conditions of scarcity
Geography	The study of space, place, environment, and the relationship between human societies and the physical world
History (Kasaysayan)	The study of past events, their causes, and their consequences; from saysay, meaning meaning or significance
Linguistics	The scientific study of language structure, variation, change, and social role
Political Science	The study of power, governance, political behavior, and political systems
Psychology	The scientific study of the human mind, behavior, and mental processes
Sociology	The study of human society, social structures, groups, institutions, and social relationships
Demography	The study of human populations: size, composition, distribution, and change
Globalization	The increasing interconnectedness of economies, cultures, and political systems across the world

Review Questions

1. Choose three social science disciplines from this lesson. For each, state one main area of inquiry, one key method, and one career opportunity.
2. What is the difference between microeconomics and macroeconomics? Provide an example of a question each would ask.
3. Compare sociology and anthropology in terms of their historical focus, typical methods, and key concepts.
4. Explain how globalization has influenced economics as a discipline and as a lived reality.
5. List four fields of anthropology and briefly describe what each studies.
6. What is the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis in linguistics? What does it suggest about the relationship between language and thought?
7. Identify three major political theories. For each, state one core idea and one key thinker.
8. What is the difference between a controlled experiment and a correlational study in psychology? Which one can establish causation?
9. Define demography. List four factors that demographers study when analyzing population change.
10. Application question: A researcher wants to understand why poverty rates vary across different neighborhoods in a large city. Which social science disciplines might contribute to this research? For each discipline you name, explain what specific contribution it could make.